This Crusade was already sputtering, very slowly, towards the Holy Land. Since August of 1198—eight months after his election—Pope Innocent III had been pleading for a renewal of the crusading effort. He had sent a letter to every head of state in Europe, begging each to commit to a March 1199 departure for the Holy Land. The usual rewards were offered—full pardon for sins and eternal salvation, plus the more immediate promise of debt relief—but this call to crusade had a distinctly judgmental tone. “The Cross of our Lord Jesus Christ is held in hostile hands,” Innocent wrote, “. . . [while] our princes . . . give themselves over to adulterous embraces . . . and harass one another in turn with inexorable hatred.” Indeed, England and France were at war; the kings of Christian Spain were fighting each other instead of the Almohads; Philip II of France had shut his wife in a convent so that he could marry again; Philip of Germany was struggling with a splinter group of nobles who had elected the second son of Henry the Lion, Otto, as a rival king. There were plenty of sins that needed forgiving.[2]

But all this Christian infighting meant that none of these kings were secure enough to leave their thrones untended and go on crusade. By 1201, King Emeric of Hungary was the sole monarch to answer the pope’s call. But he had been joined by a healthy contingent of French noblemen, German barons, and English knights, and popular enthusiasm for another crusade had been whipped into froth by a charismatic French preacher named Foulques who had traveled through the countryside, calling on the faithful to take the cross. A crusading army had come to life, but without kings, royal navies, or royal treasuries, it had no good way to get to Jerusalem.

The French Crusader Geoffroy de Villehardouin, who wrote an eyewitness account of the Fourth Crusade, tells us this problem was addressed by six French noblemen who went to Venice (where they would find “a greater number of ships . . . than at any other port”) and negotiated with the Doge of Venice for a fleet that would transport them to the Holy Land. The Doge, Enrico Dandolo, was ninety years old and nearly blind, but in full possession of his wits. When negotiations were finished, the Crusaders had agreed to pay 85,000 marks—a quarter again as much as Richard the Lionheart’s ruinous ransom—for ships and provisions.[3]

But when the Crusaders assembled at Venice in June 1202, as planned, less than a third of the expected force showed up—and a good many of the would-be holy warriors were too poor to chip in. The Crusaders managed to collect less than a quarter of the required payment. And there lay the fleet in front of them, out of reach.

Enrico Dandolo let them fret for a while before making a proposal: Venice had lost one of its treasured strongholds, the port city of Zadar, to Hungary. If